Dec 11 1944
Bags of bullshit here – guard mountings, brass polishing, etc. etc. We unloaded the trucks (the usual balls-up, carrying back and forth). After dinner, kit inspection. Foot made it like a Gestapo inquisition. I was much in demand as interpreter, especially for the Coy vino bar. After dinner walked round the town, solo, then met Pinky, went with him to the bar, there met Dick and the Phillipses...

Dec 12 1944
I started work, cleaning the mortar, but then Cpl. Hartley borrowed me as interpreter. He, I, Richardson and Norton took the owner of the wine shop and his brother in the 3-tonner for vino. …

"CSM Smythe stood on a table, which gave way. Bob ended up paralytic … I got in bed after a fashion. Sick in my tin hat! Not a man in the Coy sober!"



British soldiers of the Queen's Regiment celebrate Christmas in Italy, 25th December 1943. (Photo from the Imperial War Museum)

Half-way, we found we were going to Ortona, 65 miles away! Gave lifts to 2 squaddies (from the Y and L) [modern annotation reads: 'deserters'!], and two American negroes. Stopped at Pescara and got figs and apples. The Eytie went to see a friend, and brought us back a bottle of Lacrima d'Oro – exquisite wine.

Reached Ortona about 1.30. The Eytie tried to take us to a restaurant, but it was out of bounds, so we waited at the vino house, and he brought us fried fish and pork chops! We got the vino on, then waited for some vermouth a long while. We had no lights, so left without it. Reached Pescara just at sunset, just in time to avoid being nabbed. Norton drove like a hero, but was baffled when it became dark. Eventually he fitted his inspection lamp up, and we got back about 8 ... A nice trip back to my old haunts.

Dec 17 (Sun) 1944
... Called at an Eytie bar, and saw Joe Hasleton. He told me Ken Moores was dead [Ken Moores was mentioned on January 24 in Sicily, singing at a talent contest], and Joe Hall wounded in the Fifth army. Finished up at the B.G., a sing-song, got rather addled.

Dec 20 1944
... Managed to get a letter written and to clean the rust off my bayonet. Went out with Dick and the Phillipses.

We called on the wine merchant, and had some cherry brandy. While we were there, Nobby Clarke [The Nobby in the photo with Jim and Dick Gill?] and his CSM came in for half an hour. [Modern annotation: 'I think they stalled a deal to sell surplus'!]

Dec 24 (Sun) 1944
… After tea went up to the Amicis, who made me very welcome. The granny 'adopted' me for the night in place of her son who is a prisoner. An enormous supper – pasta, cod, roast eel (smashing) with salad, roast chestnuts and, of course, bread and vino. Emma and her mother went out afterwards. I stayed talking till 9; they were very alarmed about my being a Protestant, but very friendly.

I went up to the operator's room, where Ted was on duty, they were well gone when I arrived. We finished the cherry brandy, then I brought a bottle of Marsala in (and drank most of it). I also had about 10 glasses in the canteen.

The sgts and officers were in. CSM Smythe stood on a table, which gave way. Being drunk, I plagued Bell about guard mounting tomorrow, and also Major Gill about something. Bob ended up paralytic, and had to be put to bed. I was drunker than ever before, but got in bed after a fashion. Sick in my tin hat! Not a man in the Coy sober!

"We are for Greece ...Loaded the trucks with ammo and kit"

Dec 25 (Xmas Day) 1944
No hangover! Went to a carol service at the theatre at 9.30. …Tables and chairs for the whole company, even plates.The officers and sergeants brought the food round, also free beer and vermouth. Everyone drunk, lots of fun. The officers and CSM got some very rude remarks. Soup, pork, turkey (tinned), sausage stuffing and apple sauce, potatoes, plum pudding – multo buono. Finally oranges and nuts. Finished dinner 3.30, went on guard 3.45. Everyone drunk, so only a token mounting – 11 men ...Did first stag in pleasant haze. Grand tea, pork, peas and potatoes, apple and whipped cream.... A cold, but perfectly clear night. Gill confirmed at dinner that we are for Greece.

Dec 26 1944
… After tea went to the Amicis, made welcome again, cake and vino. Stayed a good while talking. Got my washing done, but they would take no payment. Met the lads again (the twins and Sid), talked with them in our billet with the old woman who owns it. Went on to the canteen, then called on to attend a little Eytie girl with a bad finger. Sgt Parkes did the job, so all ended well. Mr Churchill in Greece. [See info below]

Dec 27 1944
Loaded the trucks with ammo and kit – chock-full they are, too. Loading party available – myself, Charley Ward and three corporals! Sgt. Foot has now accomplished the feat of telling off the three other sergeants in the same week! Spent the aft. principally in receiving pay and comforts. I was lucky, and drew some dried fruit! Nearly broke, so drew 1000 L. … Leave party back.

Dec 28 1944
…. Baggy and I were then put on a fatigue, carrying the empty bottles from Xmas to the canteen. I made it last all day, thus avoiding a route march. ... After tea went to the Amicis for an hour, took a few buckshees. Had some wine there. Back for supper, then the lads took me to a casa about a mile outside town. Three nice girls there, they wanted to give us supper, but we agreed to come tomorrow instead. …

Dec 29 1944
…After tea we went off to last night's place. …The landlord was there, so we got nowt done, but had an interesting talk with him and plenty of vino. Returned merry.



Above: an Italian woman with her grandchildren sits in front of her demolished house at Castleforte, once a beautiful town (May 1944). Many Italian civilians suffered considerable hardship from the war being fought around them. (It sounds here as though Jim has liberated a few spares from army stocks to give his Italian friends.)

Dec 31 (Sun) 1944
Got off church parade to attend to Cptn Green's foot....game of billiards with Phillips after tea – a great improvement on last time. I won 48-47 with a break of 10. Later went drinking with Sadler. Got very drunk. Remember nothing from about 9.30 till I woke in bed about 3 ...

1945

"I hope that I am as well satisfied this time next year and that Hitler and his lot are done for"

Jan 1 1945
… Bad hangover, so slept till dinner. … Several inches of snow on the ground … Anyway, I am still alive and whole, and it has been an interesting year. I hope that I am as well satisfied this time next year – and that Hitler and his lot are done for.

[From **Jan 8** the diary is for some time written on brown paper in smudgy pencil that is often virtually impossible to read. At this time Jim's unit are preparing to move. What can be read isn't good news: '… all the carriers went today. An A Coy carrier overturned, one man killed.' On **Jan 9:** '… Went to the Amicis first, to say goodbye … Mama very sorry to see me go … I set to work to pack all my kit up, by candlelight.' And on **January 16:** 'Letter from home. Granny dead.']

"Talk about flap – we didn't know whether we were going to fight Elas or embark for Blighty"

Feb 17 1945
Boarded ship.Strict blackout at night because we passed within 50 miles of Crete. [Although mainland Greece had been liberated in October 1944, the Aegean islands remained in German hands.]

Feb 18 1945
Billets in a villa in a suburb of Athens, very smart and clean. The town looked very bashed about as we came through.

Feb 20 1945
Very cold … all the mountains behind Athens are white.

Feb 21 1945
… Cpl. Hartley rushed in, shouted, 'Pack up, ready to move by 8!' Talk about flap – we didn't know whether we were going to fight Elas or embark for Blighty [UK]. Eventually it turned out that we only had to stand by in case of trouble in Athens.

March 5 1945
Woke about 7, just as the ship neared the coast.We nosed in at a little harbour, littered with wrecked trucks we left behind in 1940. Drove straight off to join D Coy at Missolonghi. Decent billets in a barracks, but no lights. … We loaded a pile of Elas rifles on to a truck. All sorts of arms there, British, Eytie, Jerry and nondescript. … We met a Royalist lad, John Kootis, who took me to a watchmender's.

March 8 1945
... We moved to Agrinion up in the hills. … Out at night, drank a bottle of Retsina on my own. … When the bars closed, I wandered off on my own, and a Greek civvy took me in a bar and bought me drinks. I was too tight to understand him, but I think I was toasting the communists! Back to billets, feeling the effects rather badly. Someone made the corporals French beds.

March 21 1945
Reveille at 4, off before dawn. ... We spent the day helping the National Guard to search two villages for arms. Warm work, but interesting, and we got bags of free booze. The Guard seemed more interested in communists than arms, and arrested dozens of them. I got rather fed up with their bullying ways. We got back about 3, pretty merry, and my equipment in a bad state. ...

March 23 1945
Off to Krioneri. ... cushy here, we just have to unload the landing craft when they arrive. ... Baggy got dead drunk, and wanted to kill me!

March 26 1945
Richardson 28 days F.P. for chasing the CSM [Company Sergeant Major] with a bayonet. Laidlaw 14 days for aiding and abetting. Sadler 14 days – for bashing the CSM!



A rifleman acts as 'tail-end Charlie', guarding the commander of a Sherman tank from snipers during operations against ELAS in Athens, 18 December 1944. (Photo from Imperial War Museum)

Posting to Athens

Greece was successfully invaded by Germany in April 1941, despite Britain having sent troops to aid the Greeks. From 1942 a resistance movement became increasingly successful, liberating a large part of the country's mountainous interior.

However, conflict grew between the resistance groups, one of which was the left-wing National Liberation front EAM (and its military arm ELAS) which wanted power after the war. As the end of the war approached, the British Foreign Office, fearing a communist upsurge, observed ELAS's growing power warily.

When the British head of allied forces in Greece announced an ultimatum for disarmament of guerilla forces, a demonstration by EAM on Dec 3 ended in the deaths of 28 demonstrators. Some sources blame the British for this. It ended in 37 days of fighting in Athens between EAM/ELAS and the forces of the government and British army.

Churchill arrived in Athens on Dec 25 1944 to try to bring about a settlement. Evidently matters were still so unstable in Athens that troops were needed, and Jim's unit were sent there in February.

(The various Greek parties signed a treaty in 1945. However, From 1946 to 1949 there was a civil war between leftist guerillas and the British and American-sponsored conservative government.)

March 30 1945
...Turned back [after climbing a mountain], but missed the way down. Kept on down the ravine, but it ended in a sheer drop. I got a terrific flap on, and charged up the hill like mad. Couldn't find the way down, and got very thirsty. Searched till dark, then lay down, meaning to sleep till morning.

When the moon rose, I began searching again. I worked my way systematically down the ridge until eventually I stumbled on the way down. Just managed to reach camp by reveille. Scratched, bruised, sore and tattered, but very thankful to be all in one piece.

March 31 1945
It turned out that there had been quite a fuss last night over my absence. Doncaster got drunk, and went out looking for me with a Tommy gun. He fell into the stream and got wet through.

April 9 1945
A rather good-looking girl turned up, and arranged to sleep with [name in shorthand]. Quite a disturbance she caused. … Mick and Eddie set out to try and get the girl out of the bivvy. Instead, they woke the wrong occupant, and got chased. I was supposed to be on guard 4.30 – 6.30, but wasn't woken till 6! Saw the girl emerge, both looking rather haggard.

April 17 1945
...We passed the Ionian isles, sun, sky and dark blue water … Spent the evening playing knock-out whist, and slept under the table again. [Returning to Italy.]

"the CO spoke to us, saying how pleased he was that we would be 'in at the kill' "

April 18 1945
Arrived Taranto about 9, docked on the mainland. Decked ourselves like Xmas trees [?] again, and staggered off. Straight by lorry to the old area, actually to Alexander lines, the very next camp to our old one. ... It looks as though the Blighty rumours have had it. ... All wish we were back at Patros.

April 22 1945
... the CO spoke to us, saying how pleased he was that we would be 'in at the kill', and informing us that we would leave for Cesena In about a week.

April 29 1945
… Smashing news, Mussolini and his gang shot, 5th army in Milan, partisans in Venice, Americans in Munich.

May 1 1945
… Nearly all the Coy, including myself, had diarrhoea, though. Every time the convoy stopped, about 20 blokes raced for the nearest hedge! Very deadly… Camped in the outskirts of San Benedetto...

May 2 1945
Reveille at 6, thanks goodness. Moved up to Cesena, with a halt at Fano. Passed much familiar country, but almost empty of troops now. Lots of pretty girls on bikes. … Then the bombshell: 'The Germans in Italy have surrendered!' Just about time, too.

End of the war

In Italy, the allies mounted a final offensive in spring 1945. The Eighth Army's part in this is summarised by Eighth Army News of July 1945:

*The Enemy was routed from the Argenta Gap by **April 19**, and the Po crossings came within range of the 8th's guns.*

*On **April 21** Polish troops entered Bologna. Ferrara fell on **April 24**. Prisoners were being taken in large numbers. By **April 25** there were secure bridgeheads across the Po. On **April 28** the Adige R. was crossed on a broad front, and on **April 29** Eighth Army troops entered Venice.*

*The advance continued, and Udine was entered on **May 1**. Overnight our troops advanced ... to link up with the forces of Marshal Tito coming from the east. On **May 2, 1945**, The German C-in-C surrendered. The Eighth Army had fought and won its last battle.*

On **27 April** 1945, as allied forces closed in on Milan, Benito Mussolini was captured by Italian partisans while trying to flee to Switzerland. He was killed on **28 April**, and his body hung for public display in Milan.

On **30 April** as the battle of Berlin raged above him, Hitler realised all was lost and committed suicide in his bunker

On **1 May** the German authorities in Italy ordered all German forces to cease hostilities and signed a surrender document stipulating all were to surrender unconditionally to the allies on 2 May. The Battle of Berlin ended on **2 May**. A document was signed that all German forces were to cease active operations on **May 8**.



Above: Italian partisan in Florence, August 14 1944. The term 'Partisans' refers to various Italian resistance groups fighting the German occupation. Italian Partisans executed Benito Mussolini.



Children playing on a captured German Tiger tank in Forli (Mussolini's birthplace), 1945. Painting (Imperial War Museum) by Edward Ardizzone.

"An announcement came through ... that tomorrow would be VE day. We all forthwith set out to get canned"

May 4 1945
…. went down to the 'Bowling Green' to write home. However, news came through about the surrender of the German armies in the North, so we had a celebration instead, and I got mildly drunk. Cpl. Thorley recited 'Eskimo Nell' very well. Somehow, though, all this good news falls a little flat. I think it is because we were all keyed up to go back into action, and now that is over we are going back to the old routine.

Now (the 5th) I can't even remember which day the news of Hitler's death came through! Damned good show, all the same.



VE Day street party with bonfire (Picture from Imperial War Museum)

May 7 1945
… The morning news told us to expect the end of the war at any hour, so everyone waiting. … We spent the morning loading the mortars for a move on Tuesday or Wednesday, and the aft. lazing about and also preparing an open-air stage for victory celebrations!

An announcement came through after tea that an armistice had been signed, and that tomorrow would be VE day. We all forthwith set out to get canned, first in the wine shop and then in the canteen. Bags of booze and singing. The officers came in to fraternise … Everyone very matey and riotous – we tore the maps off the walls. Possy, Brewer, Chick, the twins and Paddy Gavin were all leading lights. When we came out the other units were firing Very lights etc. I looked for our stuff, couldn't find it, so fired 20 rounds into the air as a *feu de joie*! And so to bed.

[A *feu de joie* - 'fire of joy' in French - is a rifle salute on occasions of national rejoicing.

A Very - or Verey - is a type of flare gun, usually used for signalling.]

May 8 1945 - VE Day
Still a little tipsy when I awoke, but otherwise O.K. Spent the day lazing around in gym shorts, reading etc. Heard Mr Churchill's speech. … All of the Bn.[Battalion] that are still here came down at 7 for a

"Bags of celebrations at C Coy … Johnny Mason and I did a war dance together"

celebration - tea, vino, rum and cake. They put a bit of a show on, and we had a sing-song. Sgt. McCormick was a great success as a ... dancer, and Cpl. Hilton dressed up as a Signorina.

The C.O. was there, and all the officers. We heard the King's speech, after which the party broke up. Went looking for Very lights, but couldn't find them. Ran over to C Coy, though, a perfect barrage of them. A near miss caused me to sit down in a rather wet ditch! Bags of celebrations at C Coy, triumphal dances etc. Johnny Mason and I did a war dance together, then there was a sing-song. I went round all their trucks, blowing the horns. … Stopped on the way to collapse one of the Sgts.' bivvies.

Met Micky Lydon, also looking for Very lights (and mischief). We let Coy H.Q.'s bivvies down, and decorated our own pla's with camouflage nets, scrim and other odd debris. And so to bed.

May 12 1945
… off at 11 for a day out at Cervio. … Spent the whole day on the beach, really smashing … bags of fun with the corporals, overturning a skiff in the possession of Sgt. Foot. One of the best days I have had in the army. Bags of pretty girls to see on the way. ...

"It feels pretty good to be on the soil of the (former) 3rd Reich"

May 13 1945
… We were told to be ready to move by 11 AM (to [illegible] in Austria, I believe). A terrific flap at first, dying off as it became obvious that we would not move today. We attended the Victory Service. … Heard Mr Churchill's speech at 9 PM.

May 14 1945
… Reveille at 5 … we moved off about 9.30! Up the Via Emilia to Imola … Terrific devastation at the Reno, Po and Adige crossings. Argenta was badly flattened too. … Crossed the Po and Adige on pontoon bridges … Rather a crowded truck, 7 men and about 10 kits, so we took it in turns to ride on the roof. Passed many pretty girls on bikes, multo buono, and some German prisoners.

May 15 1945
Reveille at 2, moved off about 4. … the Alps gradually emerging from the N. Many defence earthworks (possibly Musso's old defences against Germany). … Set off, up a valley in the Julian Alps. Tall, snowy peaks, swift green streams, steep gorges and the usual spiral roads...



May 1945: British military transport carrying supplies for the 8th army pass the frontier station on the border between Italy and Austria. A British MP gives guidance. (Picture from the Imperial War Museum)

A steep narrow road up to the divide, with a demolished village. Half the trucks stopped, with radiators boiling.

On the Italian side, everyone was Slovene, with lots of Tito's partisans. Then careered down another steep, narrow road overhanging a lake, through a tunnel in the mountains to the valley of the Danube basin. … then into Austria. Only a pole at the frontier, with an M.P. checking travellers.

Then we came to inns with German names, men in the traditional dress of shorts, and everything just like the Tyrol guide-books. … Most of the civvies just ignored us, though a few girls smiled... We passed many lorry-loads of Tito's partisans, oddly dressed but very cheerful, also thousands of men were wandering round in nondescript German uniforms. I don't know whether they were deserters, Volkssturm or what. They were all miserable. Lots of pubs, and we soon saw our squaddies out with Austrian girls. A few civilian refugees, a little bomb damage, but not much.Just After Klagenfurt we had a rainstorm. Arrived about 10, billeted in a big barn. … It feels pretty good to be on the soil of the (former) 3rd Reich.



A pontoon Bailey Bridge over the Rover Po near Ferrara, 1945. Picture (from the Imperial War Museum) by Edward Bawden. Remains of a steel girder bridge can be seen, with lorries and tanks crossing its replacement.

Partisans, Volkssturm, Cossacks

The Yugoslav Partisans were a Communist-led World War 2 anti-fascist resistance movement commanded by Marshal Josip Broz Tito. The Volkssturm was a German national militia. Founded on Hitler's orders in October 1944, it conscripted males not already serving in some military unit. Cossacks - horsemen of the Russian Steppes and Caucasus mountains - could be found on both sides during the war, but it's thought the majority fought in the Red Army.

May 16 1945
… set off about mid-morning on the last lap. Only a few miles, as far as a small flax factory. Our job is to collect Jerry equipment to store in the factory. We had a pleasant surprise when they took us to a nice open field and said, 'Put your bivvies up.' I cursed for a solid hour. … To cap it all, it poured down. We had some German prisoners making bed-boards for us. I was appointed interpreter. … Also talked with a Frenchman who has been a prisoner on the farm for 5 years. Pretty cheesed off to think of us in leaky tents, and these Germans in casas! …

May 17 1945
I am official 21c to Cpl. Brewer, who is in charge of the prisoners, so spent most of the day keeping them busy, cookhouse, carpentry and cleaning trucks. … A German tart came up to some of the lads, and seemed very willing, but Sgt. Dalziel kept us from speaking to her.

May 18 1945
Lovely news – on the move again. We had to go to join C Coy at BHQ, to help them out with guards, apparently. … Passed a lot of army carts (Hungarian) with brown-uniformed soldiers and many civvies. Also hundreds of soldiers with horses, many wearing Cossack [illegible]. In bivvies again … We have to take our rifles with us when we leave camp now.

May 19 1945
Spent the morning sorting out German equipment in our dump. Nothing of use to me. … I went out with Pinky through Guttarin and then to another village, in search of booze. Passed through a big camp of Hungarian troops. Found a very nice pub, just like an English country pub, where we got Must, which is a kind of cider but quite strong.… Came back slightly merry.

May 20 1945
… Went down with Wilding in the aft., to the Cossack camp to try and get him riding lessons. … Things noticed: thousands of German, Russian and Hungarian troops streaming past on little wooden carts, and numberless horses ... We had a look at a crashed F.W.190, and met a Ukrainian [?] worker, who didn't want to go back because of 'Bolshevismus' …

May 21 1945
Up about 5, a general rush, and got on truck with bivvies … the C.O. got mad, and bollocked us for being dirty. When we reached the Croat camp, we had to polish up for them, and Major Gill came down to inspect us. The job was to escort 500 Croats in the Wehrmacht to the Tyrolean border. They rather expected to be shot on arrival, so weren't very cheerful. Many were very young.

We arrived at Bleiburg (after Cptn. Green had lost the way), and then had to search these and 1500 others … There was a mad scramble for pistols and watches. When Bentley asked one man for his gun, he shot himself through the mouth. ... No one took the slightest notice of the incident. I also got a Wehrmacht belt for 10 fags (not a very willing sale). On the way we passed a crowd of Partisans in German vehicles. I spoke to some, and two turned out to be Germans, captured and pressed into service.At Bleiburg I spoke to some women Partisans, and to a man who turned out to be Russian. Passed the usual thousands of Cossacks.

May 23 1945
Not a bad day on guard. Rather nervous about the stack of ammo and detonators we have. Lots more vehicles arriving. In one I found some letters to an Austrian soldier – things must have been bad here last winter. All our kit was moved during the day to a barn in the village …





Above: Cossacks;
Right: SS troops filing out on their way to captivity after being surrounded and forced to surrender in Milan, 30 April 1945.(Picture from Imperial War Museum.) However, as Jim was shortly to discover, they were not all committed to surrender!

"We went down to B Coy, to escort to another area a bunch of SS prisoners who had been causing trouble"

May 25 1945
… I was half way through scrubbing my KD slacks when the order came to be on truck in half an hour. One wild whirl, and I landed on wearing the wet slacks. We went down to B Coy, to escort to another area a bunch of SS prisoners who had been causing trouble. Only two of us in each 3-tonner, so we were all ready, and I had my gun inside my shirt. No trouble though. They were singing about 'Flying to London', and also the SS anthem. Landed at a hamlet near Volkermarkt about 9. They slept in one barn, we in another, very comfortable.

May 26 1945
... Everyone very alert all the time. We got a wire from some Yugoslavs that an escape was planned during the night, so at dusk we had a real do, a sentry at all sides with a Bren and a truck to floodlight the barn. Everyone got trigger-happy, especially when another lot arrived. They sang a lot, but a heavy shower quietened things for the night.

May 27 (Sun) 1945
Fine again, quite home-like, with the people coming down to church. Came off at 10, and had the rest of the day off, bar interpreting. Most of the SS men were taken away at the same time, assisted by some hefty kicks from the officers, but about 20 civvy war criminals came in the evening. I cleaned my revolver and had some practice. It fires all right, but pulls and kicks a lot. Shots going off all day. We had a cask of beer and some whiffs in the evening! Someone new, an Arab in the German army.

May 28 1945
On guard again. Nothing very interesting. We had a very pukka mounting to impress the prisoners. Otherwise cushy. A much quieter crowd now. Some of them, including the blondes, turned out to be legation staff here in error, so they are now in our bivvies near the guard room.

May 29 1945
… Had my biggest first aid case yet, a badly cut finger. No trouble. Some of our lads shot a deer. The prisoner interpreter has moved down amongst us now, and told us many interesting things.

May 30 1945
… Reports of trouble with the Cossacks, and of a scheme for home leave.

May 31 1945
On guard again. Rather more cushy now that the SS are away. Two pretty Austrian nurses came to see one of the prisoners.



The SchutzStaffel (Protective Squadron) or SS were the elite corps of the Nazi party. They were formed in 1925, and acted as a personal bodyguard for Adolf Hitler. One branch were the Gestapo, or secret police. In 1935 they were given the task of establishing concentration camps for groups such as Jews, gypsies and Communists. The combat arm had the official title Waffen SS (Literally 'Weapons SS') from 1940 onwards. Various uniforms existed, the black one being the best known. The Waffen SS combat units wore field-grey.



Left: SS officers at the Mauthhausen Concentration camp during Heinrich Himmler's visit, Austria, date unknown (Photo: German Federal Archives)

June 3 1945
… The lads pinched 4 horses from a convoy yesterday for riding. Bags of fun, especially with the novices.

June 4 1945
… Went to the mobile baths at Volkermarkt. … Held up on the way back because F.M. Alexander was at Div. H.Q. Went up in the hills before tea to try my pistol out again, found it pretty accurate this time. The lads came in at night with two deer across their shoulders, skinned them on the spot. ...

June 7 1945
We had a general parade at 9 AM, to warn us about our pistols being forbidden. Went to Klagenfurt after dinner, had an excellent time. We went to the lido on the lake shore, had a swim … then to the cinema to see a 'western', quite thrilling. … We got a fresh lot of horses yesterday. [Why did they need a western for thrills? They had guns and outlaws, waggon trains and horse-rustling...]

June 8 1945
On guard once more. Rather awkward in the morning, nearly every sentry out on escort. The German officer [next word unclear] was very obliging, he had a sun-shelter built for me. The prisoners are also wiring the paddock in. ... Davy brought Bambi, his pet fawn, round to see the blonde.

June 20 1945
...Set off after supper on Sid's bike, rode to Volkermarkt. ... remarkable biblical tableaux in the church walls; it had a chime for all the world like Ingleton church, [Jim's dad came-from Ingleton village] and for a moment it took me back there.

June 23 1945
Heard Bevin's election speech. [British general election]

“Joe Marsh had used petrol to clear foul ground near the latrine, and when Possy lit a fag...”

June 24 1945
… Still bags of medical duties, but I missed one case. Joe Marsh had used petrol to clear foul ground near the latrine, and when Possy lit a fag on the latrine it blew up, and scorched his behind. The Field Hygiene people bandaged him up and packed him off in dock.
…After supper went up to the compound and talked with our fair prisoner, got on well but she had another weeping fit.

June 26 1945
D Coy horses came here for the races tomorrow, and licked our fancied white mare easily. Gill put Davey under close arrest for allowing his (Gill’s) dog to stray!

July 3 1945
... My voting papers arrived. Apparently we are not moving yet. Instead, a fresh lot of prisoners are expected.



The result of Britain’s 1945 election was a surprise landslide victory for Clement Attlee’s Labour party over Winston Churchill’s Conservatives, giving Labour its first majority government.

Churchill had been a hugely respected wartime leader, but Labour’s peacetime promises proved irresistible: full employment, a tax-funded National Health Service and the Welfare State. Their campaign message was: ‘Let us face the future’.

Left: Eighth Army going to the polls in Austria, July 8 1945.



In London’s Piccadilly circus, crowds celebrate the news that the war in Japan is over. (Photos from Imperial War Museum.)

“VJ Day ... drank till the vermouth gave out”

July 23 1945
... We are guarding a dump where confiscated Jewish property is sorted out, and sent off by the Red Cross. Many pretty girls working there, bags of frat. [Fraternisation. Jim mostly writes in German of his Austrian romantic adventures.] Also, in the billet, Herma, Greta and her mother. Got on well, though others claimed [underlined] to get on better.

July 24 1945
… More fratting with Hildegarde, Frieda, Anna, Martha etc. My German is highly thought of. Herma (a very decent woman) seems to like me.

July 26 1945
...election results, Labour in by a big majority. Most of us pleased.

July 27 1945
… A good run through hills and forests … Came through Graz, which looked terribly blitzed but a grand big place. Flags out all through Styria, and after Graz kids with flowers, and even the odd drink of Must. Like liberating Paris! … Grand billets in a village pub.

July 28 1945
… dodged a parade, at which Gill got the 94 village Nazis lined up, and made a speech to them. Went out fratting afterwards, mainly with Mottram. ... had a look at a Jerry S.P. gun … Everyone telling tales about the Russians raping, looting etc.

July 29 1945
… out walking in the evening. … found a farm where I was the first British soldier to call. They told me the usual stories about the Russians raping and looting, and gave me a drink of Must.

Aug 9 1945
… More details about the atomic bomb. It scares me! Suppose a Nazi got hold of one!

Aug 10 1945
... The lads say the Japs are willing to surrender.

Aug 15 1945
Div. phoned through that this was to be VJ Day ... Back to the canteen and drank till the vermouth gave out. Chick and Possy in a state - they had tried to sort the Sergeants’ mess out, and got sorted out themselves. Sadler and Joe Dunk [probably short for Dunkerley] both ‘casualties’. Not so hot myself.

“By truck to the docks and straight on the ship .... Saw the White Cliffs of Dover, looking very majestic”

Nov 29 1945
... Packed up, then hung around till 3.30. Proceeded in the usual interminable army way, parade, wait, tram, wait, station, wait, and pulled out about 5.30. A horrible coach, wooden windows, wood seats and no heating. ...

Nov 30 1945
Woke, and found we had passed through Switzerland without my being aware of it. Rather disappointed. Foggy, and white frost everywhere, very cold. ... Spent most of the day at the corridor windows, though it was cold. ... halt near Dijon ... Pleasant country, almost exactly like England, bar a few broken bridges, German prisoners and the stuccoed houses. ... We stopped about 8 miles short of Paris, and spent the next 6 hours manoeuvring round it, getting another meal 27 km past it at 01.30 hrs. Too late to bother getting my bed down, but I was pretty comfortable in my greatcoat.

Dec 1 1945
Woke just as we were drawing into Boulogne ... reached Calais about 9. Then everything was a rush. Breakfast, documentation, money, pay, NAAFI rations and a wash and shave ... By truck to the docks and straight on the ship .... Saw the White Cliffs of Dover, looking very majestic. Drew into Folkestone just as the light faded....
Drew in at Masboro stn about 2.15 AM. Walked home, and knocked my mother and Dad up with a prop. Wakened them in a few minutes, then we all had tea and I had a snack ...To bed about 3, very content.



British soldiers home for demobilisation leave Dover docks for the railway station. (Picture from Imperial War Museum.) Jim wouldn’t be ‘demobbed’ for some time - but was on home leave after two years.

And so there followed a pleasant month of catching up on everything and everyone Jim had missed for two years. He handed out the presents he’d brought, but found some of his younger cousins altered: ‘Wilfred I wouldn’t have known... Wilf very pleased with the Jeep I brought.’

There was football: ‘Went to Millmoor to see United play Lincoln in the cup.’ Also family evenings: ‘We had an hour or more at rummy, very pleasant, just like old times.’ And his old favourite haunt, the Carlton dance class: ‘Found I hadn’t entirely forgotten, though pretty nearly.’

He went to see the old gang (such as Denzil) from the railway offices where he’d worked, and the Home Guard lads: ‘Dad took me up to the HG club. Vic, Layton, Brunney, Eyre and others were there.’

And there were the Ingleton relatives to visit: ‘Grandma very pleased to see me ... Looked in at the Wheatsheaf.’

The only sadness was that Granny in Rotherham had died while he was away at war: ‘I walked up to the cemetery, and had a look at Granny’s grave.’

Christmas Day was a time of family games: ‘A bit different to last Xmas night!’

And good news came on Dec 28: ‘On the 1 O’Clock news we heard that leave parties 275 - 281 had 24 hrs extension! Whoopee!’ So departure came on Dec 30: ‘Up late. Packed my kit and got things ready for my departure tomorrow, Dad pertinaciously helpful, even cleaned my fossilised boot-brush. ... Very pleasant - it seems a shame to go away!’

But on Dec 31 he was off on the train to London - and spending the night at a dismal military camp: ‘...made a slight route march through it to our huts ... got down about 2, and had a last pork pie. One way of seeing the New Year in!’

Jim returned to Austria - but the battalion was breaking up, and he was posted elsewhere to work in field security. His days with old pals in the Manchester Regiment were over. He would not be released from the army for another year or two - but Jim’s war was over.



Jim’s parents, Elsie and William of Rotherham, Yorkshire. It must have seemed a long two years for them while their only child, Jim, was abroad. (William served in the Home Guard during the war, while Elsie worked in a factory.)